



to Mumbai by trucks carrying sugarcane. He was also able to sell into many agricultural universities.

Being a passionate entrepreneur

After spending three years at DCM, Ajai began his entrepreneurial journey with his HCL business partners, who included Shiv Nadar, Arjun Malhotra, Pammi Puri, Subhash Arora, and Yogesh Vaidya.

Initially, they started a company named Microcomp. However, they had neither enough funds nor the mandatory license (essential at that time) to start a computer business. Ajai recalls, “We started picking up calculators from a company called TeleVista and marketed those products to gather some cash for the license fee. We kept waiting to see how we would get the license, because those days startups were not given licenses. Fortunately, we found that Uttar Pradesh (UP) government was sitting with a license. Therefore, we collaborated with the UP Electronics Corporation and formed Hindustan Computers Limited (HCL) in 1976.”

In HCL, Ajai started his work in Mumbai along with Yogesh Vaidya. Later, he took over the business in South India. He had an interesting journey as the youngest founder



Ajai Chowdhry with family

member of HCL. He recalls, “It was difficult to run a new company like HCL as opposed to an established one like DCM. However, I made some good breakthroughs in Coimbatore. The first product was a scientific engineering computer called the Micro-2200. Initially, I had to sell the product just with a brochure as the product was under development. I used to meet professors in IITs and reputed engineering institutes and request them to promote us—a bunch of young engineers. Once, I carried the products and delivered them to the professors in IIT Madras to avoid delay because the product got ready only two days before the year-end delivery deadline.” Ajai is still in touch with his first set of customers.

In 1979, HCL management decided to venture into the international market. Ajai went to Singapore for that mission. He took HCL to Singapore in 1980 and created a business

spanning ASEAN, China, and Hong Kong. In 1995, he took over the reins of HCL Infosystems and created a US\$1.6 billion organisation over the next 15 years. HCL Infosystems became the leader in hardware products, system integration, and Nokia phone distribution.

Ajai describes his journey in the international market as a great learning experience. Be it gaining knowledge about new technology from experts in the US, or identifying knowledge partners from Oxford University, or handling crude negotiation practices in the China market, he left no stone unturned to achieve success in the international market.

After establishing HCL in the international market, Ajai returned to India and continued his effort to promote HCL with the help of new technologies and new strategies. From introducing India's first home PC to developing the country's most impressive mobile distribution strategy in 1996, the company achieved many milestones under his guidance.



Ajai Chowdhry singing at a concert